

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



Laying Down a New Role

LUCKNOW Will film star Aishwarya Rai-Bachchan contest the next Lok Sabha elections from Uttar Pradesh? She may not, claim insiders of the Bachchan family. But there is no denying that she will be the new star campaigner from the Mulayam Singh Yadav-led Samajwadi Party (SP) and would visit the state often.

This was made amply clear on the occasion of the 52nd birthday of SP General Secretary Amar Singh in Barabanki on

January 27. The guest list included actors Amitabh Bachchan with son Abhishekh, Aishwarya and former chief ministers Farooq Abdullah, Om Prakash Choutala and Chandrababu Naidu of the fledgling Third Front landing in the nondescript Daulatpur village. Here, the senior Bachchan laid the foundation stone of the Aishwarya Rai Bachchan Kanya Mahavidyalaya, senior secondary school for girls.

The stone laying of the school, say observers, is

THE CEREMONY: Political bonding in Uttar Pradesh

an attempt by Amitabh to wriggle out of a land deal controversy in Barabanki. A court had ruled that the actor fudged the paperwork to buy land in the village. The Mayawati Government is likely to take the matter to the Supreme Court to "teach him a lesson" for siding with arch rival Mulayam Singh.

"Aishwarya will visit this place to take care of her school and its girls," declared Amitabh. What added to the delectable prospect of Aishwarya's political involvement in the state as a star campaigner was the fact that the ceremony was turned into a political rally by other speakers. Mulayam also reiterated that the Bachchan bahu would be active in the state in the name of empowerment of women.

In the last Lok Sabha and Assembly elections, Amitabh, Jaya Bachchan and Jaya Prada had campaigned for SP. Now Aishwarya seems to have got a new role to essay.

by Subhash Mishra

SIGNPOSTS

APPOINTED: Former army chief General (retd) **J.J. Singh** as the governor of Arunachal Pradesh.

GRANTED: Bail to **Anjum Abdul Razak Memon** by the Supreme Court. He is convicted in the 1993 Mumbai blasts case and is the brother of Tiger Memon, prime accused.

NAMED: **Sania Mirza** as Asia's number one woman tennis player by WTA, overtaking China's Na Li.



CONFERRED: On Infosys mentor **N.R. Narayana Murthy**, the Officer of the Legion of Honour, the highest civilian distinction of the Government of France. He has also been awarded the Padma Vibhushan this year.

DIED: **Kalamandalam Appukutty Poduval**, 84, eminent exponent of percussion instrument maddalam which is used in Kathakali.

VIS-A-VIS ANBUMANI RAMADOSS Union health minister versus SHAH RUKH KHAN actor

There shouldn't be any smoking scenes in movies. 52 per cent of children have their first puff of cigarette due to film celebrities.



SAURABH SINGH

We should have creative liberties because cinema is all about make-believe. We mustn't have censorship on that.

EPILOGUE: Movies show much worse than smoking on screen. Will everything else be censored too?